INSIDE STUDIO SP · VST3

MAESTRO

MIX CONDUCTOR

Step-by-step manual

Version 0.2.2 · Windows and macOS · VST3



insidestudiosp.com.br/maestro · contato@insidestudiosp.com.br

What MAESTRO is

MAESTRO is a "conductor" for your mix. You put one instance on each group of the track (kick, bass, drums, hats, synths, ambience, vocals and FX). All the instances talk to each other, with no sidechain and no routing, and work together:

- **They level the groups** to the right volume for the chosen style (psytrance, techno, house…), always relative to the KICK.
- **They shape the tone** of each group with a gentle EQ (TONE MATCH).
- **They clean up the low end**: while the kick and bass are playing, the other groups make room below 120 Hz (LOW-END GUARD).
- **They bring out what matters**: the group in FOCUS stands out and the others step back only in the frequencies where they get in the way, and only while it plays.

In a few minutes you have a **balanced rough mix** that works as a starting point for your final tweaks. It doesn't replace your ears: it handles the repetitive work so you can focus on the creative part.

Before you start

ITEM	DETAILS
Format	VST3, Windows and macOS.
Compatible DAWs	Ableton Live, Logic, FL Studio, Reaper, Studio One and Cubase (DAWs that run plugins in a single process).
Bitwig	With plugin isolation (sandbox) on, each instance only sees its own track. To use MAESTRO, run the plugins in "together" mode (no isolation).
Latency	**Zero.** Safe to use while recording or playing live.
Unprocessed sound	Before LOCK and with no FOCUS, audio passes through identical, completely untouched.

Installation and activation

1. Download the installer from the link in your purchase e-mail (or at **insidestudiosp.com.br/maestro**) and choose Windows or Mac.
2. Run the installer. The plugin goes into the system's default VST3 folder.
3. Open your DAW and, if needed, have it scan for new plugins (rescan).
4. The first time you open MAESTRO, enter the **e-mail** and the **license token** you received.

> **LICENSE.** The same token works on up to 2 computers. To switch machines, deactivate it on the old computer and the slot is freed up. To see the active license: click the `MAESTRO` logo › `License…`.

> **WITHOUT ACTIVATION**, the plugin opens but passes audio straight through, without processing anything.

STEP 1

1 Organize the track into 8 groups

MAESTRO was designed to work with **groups (stems)**: you pre-mix each channel the way you always do and send the channels to 8 groups. It also works channel by channel, but with groups the result is more stable and faster to adjust.

KICK Kick drum	**BASS** Bass, sub	**DRUMS** Snare, clap, percussion	**HATS** Hi-hats, ride, shakers
SYNTHS Leads, acid, arps	**AMBIENCE** Pads, atmospheres	**VOCAL** Vocals, vocal samples	**FX** Risers, impacts, effects

Give the groups clear names

MAESTRO figures out each group's role on its own **from the track name**. Names it recognizes: *Kick, Bass, Drums, Snare, Percs, Hats, Ride, Synths, Lead, Ambience, Pad, Vocal, FX…*

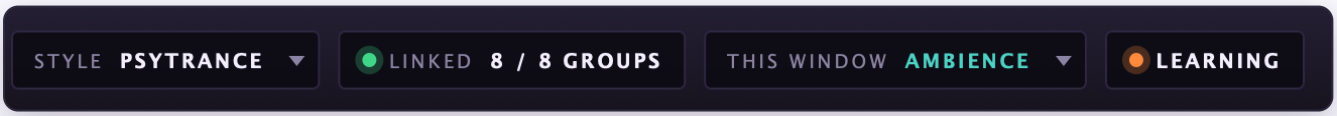
> **TIP.** Use exactly the names of the 8 groups (KICK, BASS, DRUMS, HATS, SYNTHS, AMBIENCE, VOCAL, FX). That way recognition is 100% by name and you don't need to fix anything.

If the track doesn't have a recognizable name, MAESTRO tries to guess the role **from the sound**. It gets it right most of the time, but it's a guess: check it in Step 3.

STEP 2

2 Insert MAESTRO on each group

1. Put MAESTRO on each of the 8 groups, **at the end of the chain**, after your own effects (EQ, compressor, saturation…).
2. Open any of the windows. At the top, check for `LINKED 8 / 8 GROUPS`: it means the 8 instances have found each other.



Top of the window: STYLE, how many groups are linked, this window's group and the state (IDLE, LEARNING, LOCKED).

> **CENTRAL CONSOLE.** Any MAESTRO window controls all 8 groups. You don't need to open one window per group: open just one and work from there.

STEP 3

3 Check each group's ROLE

At the top of each console strip you can see where the group's role came from:

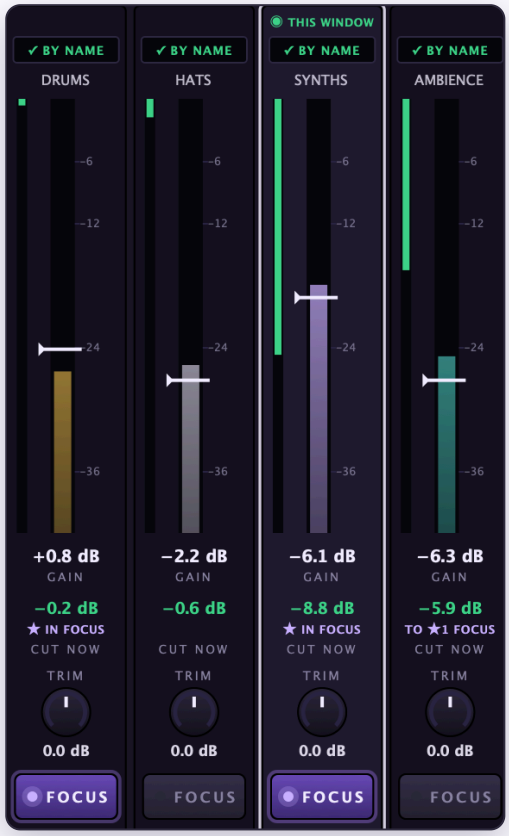
- `✓ BY NAME`: recognized from the track name. You can trust it.
- `BY SOUND`: guessed from the sound. Check that it's right.

To change a group's role, click `ROLE ▼` on its strip and choose:

- `AUTO`: by name; with no name, by sound (default);
- or one of the 8 groups manually.

If several tracks are in the same group, the menu shows one line per track.

> **IMPORTANT.** Changing the ROLE after LOCK automatically redoes the LOCK for the whole project, using what was learned during LEARN.



DRUMS, HATS, SYNTHS and AMBIENCE strips

STEP 4

4 Choose the STYLE

Click `STYLE ▼` at the top and pick the style of the track. It sets the level of each group relative to the KICK.

STYLE	USE FOR
PSYTRANCE	Full-on, dark, forest: kick and bass well up front.
PROG PSY	Progressive psy, with grooves and more spaced-out layers.
TECHNO	Techno, melodic techno.
HOUSE	House, tech house, deep.
DRUM & BASS	DnB, jungle, neuro.
POP	Pop and vocal-led songs.

The STYLE applies to the whole project. If you change the STYLE later, it only takes effect on the **next LOCK**.

STEP 5

5 LEARN: let MAESTRO listen

1. Set the playhead to the **drop** (the fullest part, where all the groups play).
2. Click `LEARN` (the button lights up and blinks).
3. Hit play and let it run for **20 to 30 seconds**.

Meanwhile, each group measures its own level and tone. The top shows `LEARNING` and the message "*LISTENING… play the drop for 20–30 s*". The sound doesn't change yet.



During LEARN: the conflict map already shows where groups clash (in red).

> **TIP.** LEARN only counts the parts where each group is playing: silence doesn't get in the way. If a group doesn't play during LEARN, it stays as it is at LOCK (the GUARD still applies to it).

STEP 6

6 LOCK: apply the balance

After the 20–30 s, click `LOCK`. Instantly, each group:

- moves to the **STYLE level**, relative to the KICK (tracks in the same group move together, so the internal balance stays as you left it);
- gets a gentle **TONE MATCH** (static 9-band EQ, ±4 dB max);
- gets the **LOW-END GUARD** active (if it's switched on).

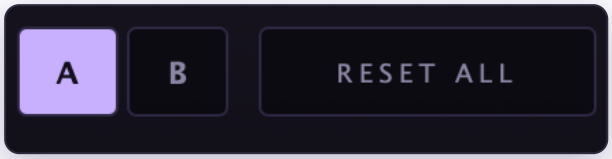
The top now shows `LOCKED`. The LOCK is saved with the project: when you reopen it, everything is as you left it.

> **LOCK WITHOUT LEARN?** If you click LOCK without having done LEARN, MAESTRO warns you: "Press LEARN first and play the drop for 20–30 s. Then LOCK."

STEP 7

7 Compare with A / B

In the bottom-right corner, switch between `A` (with MAESTRO) and `B` (the original mix, untouched). The comparison applies to the whole project at once.



> **TIP.** Compare at the same perceived loudness. MAESTRO changes group levels, and your ears tend to prefer whatever is louder.

STEP 8

8 FOCUS: bring out what matters

Click `FOCUS` on the strip of the group that needs to come through (the lead, the vocal, the snare…). You can put FOCUS on **more than one group** at a time.

- The other groups **make room only in the frequencies where they mask** the group in FOCUS, and **only while it plays** (dynamic EQ, up to the MAX CUT at most).
- Two groups in FOCUS clashing at the same frequency share the space equally (each one gives up to 3 dB).
- **KICK and BASS never step back for FOCUS**: they own the low end (the strip shows `OWNS LOW END`).
- The top shows how many groups are in FOCUS (e.g. `★ FOCUS x2`).



DRUMS and SYNTHS in FOCUS: AMBIENCE, VOCAL and FX step back (▼) only where they clash with them.

> **AUTOMATION.** FOCUS, ROLE and TRIM are DAW parameters, so you can automate them. Example: FOCUS on the vocal only in the chorus, FOCUS on the lead only in the drop.

STEP 9

9 Fine-tuning

WHOLE MIX: applies to all groups



CONTROL	RANGE / DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
AMOUNT	0–100% · **75%**	Intensity of everything: LOCK, TONE MATCH, GUARD and cuts. At 0% MAESTRO barely does anything; at 100% it applies it all.
MAX CUT	0 to −12 dB · **−6 dB**	Limit on the cut the dynamic EQ can make on a group when it steps back for a FOCUS.
SPEED	SLOW / **MED** / FAST	How fast the dynamic cuts kick in and release. FAST for fast tracks full of transients; SLOW for something smoother and more natural.
LOW-END GUARD	on/off · **on**	While the KICK/BASS plays, the other groups are lowered below 120 Hz (dynamic shelf, up to −12 dB × AMOUNT). No high-pass filters. KICK and BASS are never cut.
KEEP KICK / BASS ON TOP	on/off · **on**	KICK and BASS count as FOCUS below ~400 Hz: the other groups make room for them in the low end. Only after LOCK.

TRIM: per-group adjustment

Each strip has a `TRIM` from −12 to +12 dB. It adds to the level set by LOCK. Use it when you want a group a bit further forward or back than the STYLE suggests, without redoing the LOCK.

How to use the knobs

- **Drag** up and down. Hold **Shift** for fine adjustment.
- The **mouse wheel** over the knob also adjusts it.
- **Double-click** returns to the default value.

RESET ALL

`RESET ALL` clears the LOCK (level and tone) and turns off FOCUS on all groups, after asking for confirmation. The mix goes back to exactly how it was. Use it to start over from Step 5.

Window size

Drag the bottom-right corner to make the window bigger or smaller. The size is saved with the project.

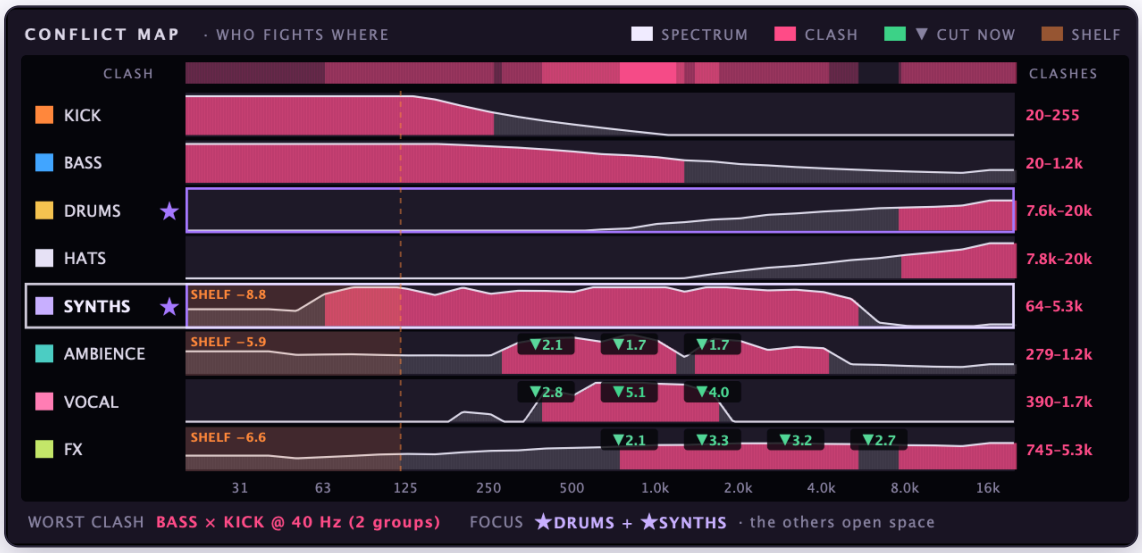
Reading the screen

Console strip (one per group)

ITEM	MEANING
BY NAME / BY SOUND	Where the group's role came from (name or sound).
Meter	Group level. The small white line is the **STYLE target**.
GAIN	How much level MAESTRO is adding or taking away (LOCK + TRIM).
CUT NOW + cause	The cut happening right now and why: **IN FOCUS** (the group is in FOCUS), **TO ★ FOCUS** (stepping back for a FOCUS), **SHELF** (LOW-END GUARD), **OWNS LOW END** (KICK/BASS, never step back).
THIS WINDOW	Marks the strip of the group this window is on.

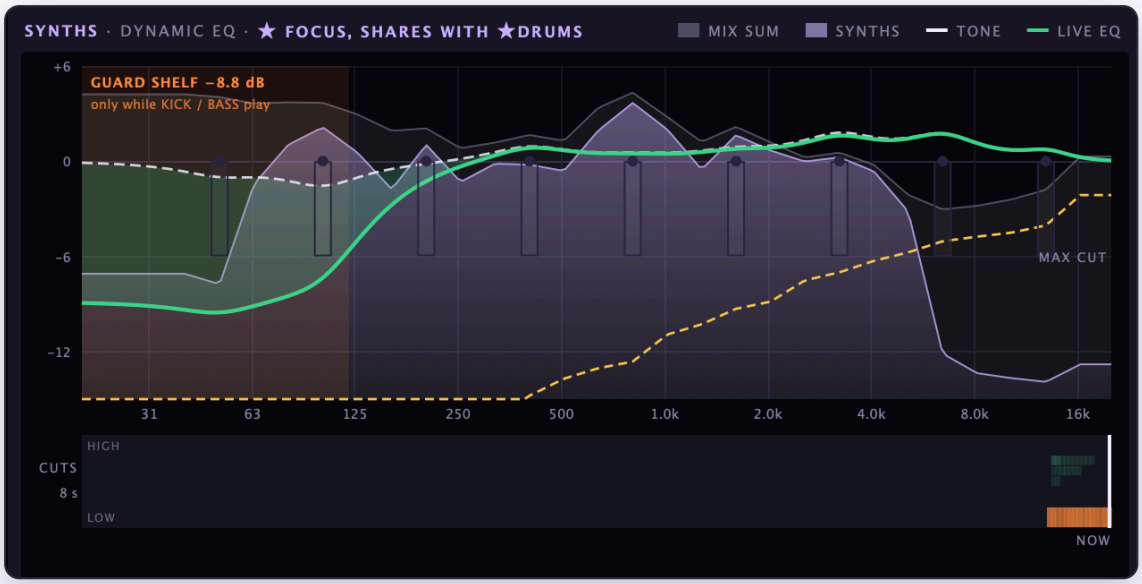
Click any strip to see that group on the map and in the EQ.

CONFLICT MAP: who clashes where



- One row per group with the spectrum in **white**; where it clashes with another group, it turns **red**.
- The **CLASH** row at the top sums up the conflicts across the whole mix. On the right, the frequency range of the clash (e.g. 20–255 Hz).
- **▼ 2.1** = a 2.1 dB cut happening right now in that region. **SHELF −8.8** = the LOW-END GUARD at work.
- At the bottom: **WORST CLASH** (the worst clash at the moment) and who is in FOCUS.

DYNAMIC EQ of the selected group



ELEMENT	MEANING
MIX SUM (gray)	Spectrum of the whole mix, in the background.
Colored area	Spectrum of the selected group.
Dashed line	Spectrum of the groups in FOCUS that this group steps back for.
TONE (white dashed)	The fixed TONE MATCH applied by LOCK.
LIVE EQ (green)	The curve in effect right now: TONE + dynamic cuts + GUARD.
9 nodes	The EQ bands (50 Hz to 12.8 kHz), with their range down to MAX CUT.
GUARD SHELF	Region below 120 Hz cut by the LOW-END GUARD (only while KICK/BASS play).
CUTS · 8 s	History of the cuts over the last 8 seconds (below the graph).

MAESTRO + MASTER DOS MAGOS

If you also use **MASTER DOS MAGOS** on the master of the same project, it automatically receives MAESTRO's 8 groups (level and spectrum) and shows **MAESTRO LINKED**. So when MAGOS points out a problem in the mix, it shows which group it's coming from. Nothing to set up, and MAESTRO's sound doesn't change.

FAQ and troubleshooting

SITUATION	WHAT TO DO
The top shows LINKED below 8	A group is missing MAESTRO or the DAW is isolating plugins (Bitwig with sandbox). Insert MAESTRO on all groups and run the plugins in the same process.
The sound didn't change at all	Normal before LOCK and with no FOCUS: MAESTRO passes audio through untouched. Also check that the license is active (logo › License…) and that A/B is set to **A**.
A group was recognized wrong	Rename the track with the group name or pick the ROLE manually (ROLE ▼). The LOCK redoes itself.
The kick or bass sound cut	Check that their ROLE is KICK and BASS. With the right role, they never step back for FOCUS or get hit by the GUARD.
It's overdone	Lower the AMOUNT (e.g. 50%) or the MAX CUT. For a single group, use TRIM.
The cuts are "pumping"	Set SPEED to SLOW or lower the MAX CUT.
I changed the arrangement or swapped sounds	Do LEARN again (20–30 s on the drop) and LOCK.
I changed the STYLE and nothing happened	The new STYLE only applies on the next LOCK. Do LEARN and LOCK again.
I want to go back to the original mix	To listen: button **B**. To undo for good: **RESET ALL**.
Duplicating a track with MAESTRO	Go ahead: the new copy doesn't inherit the original's name and takes the new track's name.

30-second summary

1. 8 clearly named groups → MAESTRO at the end of each one.
2. Check **LINKED 8 / 8** and the ROLEs.
3. Choose the **STYLE**.
4. **LEARN** + play the drop for 20–30 s → **LOCK**.
5. Compare with **A / B**.
6. **FOCUS** on what needs to come through.
7. Fine-tune with AMOUNT, MAX CUT, SPEED and TRIM.

SUPPORT. Questions, suggestions or problems: **contato@insidestudiosp.com.br** · **insidestudiosp.com.br**